MINNESOTA SENATE · DISTRICT 13

Candidate guide

Trent Dilks | Aaron Brutger | Jared Gapinski

01 The district

Senate District 13 wraps around St. Cloud in Stearns and Benton counties. It includes Sartell, much of Sauk Rapids, Albany, Avon, Clearwater, Cold Spring, Eden Valley, Holdingford, Kimball, Paynesville, Richmond, Rockville, Roscoe, St. Anthony and St. Stephen, along with about 20 townships. It contains House Districts 13A and 13B.

THE SEAT

Open

Sen. Jeff Howe (R-Rockville), in office since 2018, is retiring.

REGISTERED VOTERS

59,628

On primary day, August 11, 2026.

ELECTION DAY

Nov. 3

General election, 2026.

02 Minnesota Forward Together

Dilks and Brutger have both joined Minnesota Forward Together, a cross-party coalition organized by the Forward Independence Party, Minnesota's affiliate of the national Forward Party. The coalition brings together legislative candidates from different political affiliations who remain fully independent but commit to continuing dialogue, finding common ground and working together. Members sign a pledge to work across the aisle if elected and do not endorse one another. Its motto: "Agree where you can. Disagree where you must. Put Minnesota first." The coalition launched at the State Capitol on August 20, 2026.

Voting for a write-in candidate. Write-in votes count only when the candidate's name is written in on the ballot. **Learn more:** alethical.com

03 The candidates

Trent Dilks

DFL-ENDORSED · ON THE BALLOT

Trent Dilks lives in Maine Prairie Township in Stearns County. He served 10 years in the Minnesota National Guard, including two deployments in support of Operation Iraqi Freedom, one in Iraq and one in Kuwait. He has advocated for veterans at the State Capitol for more than a decade and is legislative director of Disabled American Veterans of Minnesota, where he helped craft Minnesota's first Veterans Omnibus Bill. His campaign priorities include government transparency and accountability, cost of living, property taxes, right to repair, health care, education and veterans.

Residence	Maine Prairie Township, Stearns County
Background	Grew up in rural Central Minnesota; Truman High School graduate
Occupation	Legislative Director, Disabled American Veterans (DAV) of Minnesota
Military service	10 years, Minnesota National Guard; two Operation Iraqi Freedom deployments (Iraq and Kuwait), including 16 months in Iraq running convoy missions
Advocacy	More than a decade advocating for veterans in St. Paul and Washington, D.C.; helped craft Minnesota's first Veterans Omnibus Bill; member of DAV's National Legislative Interim Committee
2026 race	Endorsed by the DFL; unopposed in the August 11 DFL primary
Priorities	Transparency, accountability and fraud prevention; cost of living; property taxes; right to repair; budget reform; health care; education; veterans and military families
Website	trentformn13.com

Aaron Brutger

REPUBLICAN-ENDORSED · WRITE-IN

Aaron Brutger grew up in St. Cloud and lives in Eden Lake Township. He is director of product and technology for BB Wheels/Outdoorica in Albany and is self-taught in multiple coding languages. He served on the Senate District 13 Republican executive committee from 2012 to 2025, including six years as chair. He won the 2026 Republican endorsement for this seat and continued as a write-in candidate after the August primary. His stated priorities are freedom, family and financial stability, including smaller government, fighting fraud, ending the state tax on Social Security benefits and property tax relief.

Residence	Eden Lake Township; grew up in St. Cloud
Education	Apollo High School graduate; self-taught in multiple coding languages
Occupation	Director of Product and Technology, BB Wheels/Outdoorica, Albany
Party service	SD13 Republican executive committee, 2012–2025, including six years as chair
2026 race	Endorsed by Republican delegates; running as a write-in candidate after the August 11 primary
Priorities	Freedom, family and financial stability; smaller government; ending fraud in government programs; ending the state tax on Social Security benefits; property tax relief
Website	brutgerformnsenate.com

Jared Gapinski

REPUBLICAN PRIMARY WINNER · ON THE BALLOT · INVITED

Jared Gapinski lives in Sauk Rapids and has served as Benton County Commissioner for District 4 since 2020. He previously served on the Sauk Rapids City Council from 2005 to 2012 and spent 19 years with the Sauk Rapids Fire Department, seven of them as fire captain. He is a small business owner and chairs the Association of Minnesota Counties' Public Safety Policy Committee. His campaign emphasizes combating fraud, improving public safety, reducing government bloat and securing infrastructure funding without raising taxes.

Residence	Sauk Rapids
Occupation	Small business owner
Public service	Benton County Commissioner, District 4, since 2020; Sauk Rapids City Council, 2005–2012; chair, Association of Minnesota Counties Public Safety Policy Committee; AMC Board of Directors; chair, St. Cloud Area Planning Organization Policy Board
Fire service	19 years with the Sauk Rapids Fire Department, 7 as fire captain
2026 race	Won the August 11 Republican primary with 6,449 votes (65.87%)
Priorities	Combating fraud; improving public safety; reducing government bloat; infrastructure funding without raising taxes; balanced budgets
Website	gapinskiformnsenate.com